

Article Summary and Opinion

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Name of Article	Psychosis and Mass Shootings: A Systematic Examination Using Publicly Available Data
Name of Journal	Psychology, Public Policy, and Law (American Psychological Association)
Article Authors	Jillian K. Peterson, James A. Densley, Kyle Knapp, Stasia Higgins, and Amanda Jensen
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Summary

The study by Peterson, Densley, Knapp, Higgins, and Jensen questions an assertion that is made time and again after almost every mass shooting in the United States: that mental illness causes the shooting. Instead of asking whether the shooter had a diagnosis, as studies have done in the past, they ask a much more specific and useful question. How often did the shooter act on delusions or hallucinations (symptoms of psychosis) when planning or carrying out the shooting? And how similar are shooters motivated by psychosis to other shooters? To answer this question, the researchers drew upon data from The Violence Project database. This federally funded and publicly available database contains information on the 172 individuals responsible for 168 mass public shootings occurring between 1966 and 2020. Using the Congressional Research Service definition of mass public shooting, which defines a mass public shooting as four or more people being killed with firearms in a public setting and excludes shootings related to gang activity, robbery, or familial disputes, the researchers coded 166 life history variables for each shooter using court records, manifestos, interviews, news archive searches, and other publicly available sources. All cases were independently reviewed by multiple coders. As for psychosis specifically, the researchers utilized a four-point continuum developed in prior research on offenders with mental illness: no role, minor role, moderate role, or major role. A major role indicated that the shooter was acting on delusions or hallucinations while planning and carrying out the attack and had no other apparent motive. The results indicate that psychosis played no role in approximately 70% of the shootings. Psychosis played a minor role in approximately 11% of the shootings, a moderate role in approximately 9% of the shootings, and a major role in approximately 10% of the shootings. In other words, psychosis was the primary motivation behind approximately one in ten shootings

and part of the overall motivation behind approximately three in ten shootings. The percentage of shooters motivated by psychosis remained relatively consistent throughout five decades.

However, nearly 60% of shooters had a history of mental health treatment (hospitalization, counseling, medication, etc.), and approximately 25% of shooters demonstrated evidence of a psychotic disorder - a rate significantly higher than the general population. The authors emphasize that a diagnosis in someone's past does not necessarily mean that symptoms drove the attack. Shooters motivated by psychosis were compared to other shooters based on demographics and behavioral characteristics. The comparisons revealed that there were no statistically significant differences between shooters motivated by psychosis and other shooters based on age, race, criminal history, history of violence, substance abuse, employment, or marital status. The only statistically significant difference was education level; shooters motivated by psychosis were significantly more likely to have attended college.

Furthermore, the firearm-related behaviors of shooters motivated by psychosis were virtually identical to those of other shooters. Handguns were the most commonly used type of firearm. Most firearms were purchased legally. Nearly 60 percent of the firearms used by shooters with a history of inpatient psychiatric treatment were purchased legally. The authors interpret this finding as an indication that the federal law prohibiting the sale of firearms to individuals who have been involuntarily committed is not functioning as intended. Based upon these findings, the authors contend that psychosis serves as a poor proxy for determining potential dangerousness. Rather than attempting to identify individuals who are dangerous due to psychosis, the authors recommend that policymakers focus on identifying and addressing dangerous situations and behaviors.

Specifically, they suggest implementing universal background checks; establishing extreme risk protection order laws; developing mechanisms for seizing firearms from individuals who are prohibited from possessing them after purchasing them; and creating school and workplace threat assessment teams that function similarly to crisis response rather than discipline.

Additionally, the authors suggest that policymakers consider addressing hate and fame-seeking motivations behind many shootings through measures such as restricting media coverage of perpetrators' names.

Opinion

What I appreciate most about this article is its refusal to provide a simple answer in either direction. It would have been easy for the authors to simply report that psychosis played no role in 70% of the shootings and conclude that mental illness is irrelevant; or alternatively, report that nearly 60% of shooters had a history of mental health treatment and validate the existing narrative. Instead, the authors demonstrate that both are true simultaneously, providing a more honest depiction of reality than most media outlets provide. I do believe the authors understate how much their reliance on publicly available information could affect the results. Media coverage is often skewed (the authors themselves provide examples of reporters describing White shooters as mentally ill more frequently than Black shooters), and some diagnoses were established only after arrest.

Therefore, it is possible that the psychosis estimate may be off in either direction; or that without a comparative group it is difficult to determine how atypical a 27% rate of psychotic disorders is among violent offenders generally.

While the authors acknowledge these limitations, I believe they could influence how these findings are interpreted more than they acknowledge.

However, the policy section of this article establishes why it belongs in a law journal. The fact that previously hospitalized shooters legally purchased most of their guns represents a concrete flaw in current law - not a flaw in public perception. This suggests fixing reporting and background check systems rather than attempting to predict which one of the millions of Americans living with mental illness will become violent in some distant future.